is said to have converted to the Jaina faith and ‘he did for Jainism nearly everything that Ashoka did for Buddhism such as building temples and spreading the faith.’[6] So, different traditions provide different versions of Samprati. Strangely, the last Maurya ruler in the *Ashokavadana*, Pushyamitra, is also the name of the person who is said to have *killed* the last ruler—an event which, in effect, ended the Maurya dynastic line.[7] Pushyamitra, according to the *Puranas* and the *Harshacarita*, was a general in the army of Brhidratha, from whom he usurped the throne and founded a new dynasty—that of the Shungas.[8] So, one is not even sure of the reliability of the names that make up the Maurya line in the *Ashokavadana*. What one can gather is that this text considered the Maurya Pushyamitra anti-Buddhist. Apparently he became so on the advice of a mean-minded Brahman priest and undertook to eradicate the religion by destroying the very monasteries and killing the very monks Ashoka had so zealously nurtured. It was a Yaksha along with his future son-in-law who eventually rescued Buddhism and ensured Pushyamitra’s death. With this, we are told, ‘the Mauryan lineage came to an end.’[9] Is it possible that this is a jumbled up remembrance of how the Maurya line ended? That the dynasty dropped off the horizon of ancient India because its last scion unsuccessfully sought to overturn Ashoka’s legacy is a wonderful story, especially for Buddhist admirers of the emperor, but its historical accuracy is impossible to determine.

One thing is certain. Of the later kings that figure in the Puranic and Buddhist traditions, there is only one Maurya, namely Dasharatha, who appears as a historical figure in the sense that he happens to feature in a source contemporary with his reign. This Dasharatha was a grandson of Ashoka, and, following in his grandfather’s footsteps, he made himself known through engravings on rock in structures that he caused to be built. Ashoka’s imprint on him can in fact be seen in more ways than one. Calling himself ‘Devanam-priya’, Dasharatha put up dedicatory inscriptions at